

WAC Opposition New Mexico's Lobos Call on Arizona State

TUCSON, Ariz. (AP)—Proclaiming his team sound, Jerry Kindall's Arizona Wildcats begin their defense of the Western Athletic Conference baseball title this weekend with a three-game series against Texas-El Paso.

The series opens tonight with righthander Craig Gioia, 4-2 in pre-conference play, scheduled to pitch for the Wildcats.

UTEP Coach Andy Cohen has given the starting mound assignment to lefthander George Landreth, 3-1.

Saturday, the series closes with a day-night doubleheader.

Arizona is 25-6-1 going into WAC action. UTEP is 15-9.

Kindall reviewed his team's progress Thursday, saying "I'm very satisfied. We're ready to go. Our injuries are minimal and our players are in good shape."

Last year Arizona went 16-2 in the WAC, but Kindall says that may be difficult to duplicate because of inexperience. The Wildcats lost several key players through graduation at the end of last season, including pitching standout Dave Breuker, 15-1.

But there are bright spots, which Kindall is

counting on in rebuilding his squad. They include catcher Bob Woodside, who moved up from the junior varsity early in the season and has compiled a .413 batting average. Others are Mike Gatlin in left field, Pete Van Horne at first base, Bill Dimpson at shortstop and reserve Les Pearsey at shortstop or first base.

UTEP has senior Roy Stringer back from last season at pitcher. But the righthander from Prescott, Ariz., has had arm trouble and is 1-2.

Cohen also has three of his four top hitters back, including 1974's No. 1 hitter Glenn Villarreal, who is batting .349.

"We know third base, right field and center field are in very capable hands in Ron Hassey, Dave Stegman and Ken Bolek," said Kindall.

On those players Kindall is pinning his hopes of a repeat of last season. But Arizona State also is in the southern division, and the Sun Devils are 33-6 this year.

In hitting, the Miners are behind Arizona. UTEP has a team average of .289 compared to the Wildcats' .337. UTEP pitchers, however, have an overall 3.56 ERA while Arizona trails with a 3.79 average.